



The Impact of Girls Education Restriction on Child Marriage in Afghanistan

A RIGHTS-BASED
ANALYSIS

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<https://womenrf.org/>



Since the Taliban regained control in August 2021, Afghanistan has become the only country on earth that bars women and girls from schooling beyond the primary level.

Women's Rights First reviewed the law and interviewed 40 women across 18 provinces. Their conclusion: this exclusion is directly, measurably fueling a rise in child marriage — and UN agencies warn it will worsen if the restrictions continue.

BY THE NUMBERS

2.2M

Girls denied secondary education as of March 2025

UNICEF

28%

Of Afghan women aged 15-49 married before age 18

UNICEF

~49%

Of women aged 20-24 were first married before 18

MICS 2022-23

+25%

Projected rise in child marriage if the bans continue

UN women

KEY FINDINGS

- **School exclusion drives marriage risk.** Schooling was the accepted reason to delay marriage — once it disappears, marriage becomes the default.
- **Economic pressure compounds it.** School closures deepen poverty, and marriage becomes a coping strategy for struggling households.
- **Isolation reduces girls' agency.** Without school, girls lose peer networks and the ability to resist family pressure.
- **Referral systems collapse.** Teachers and school staff, who could flag girls at risk, disappear from their lives.
- **Physical and reproductive harm follows.** Early marriage brings early pregnancy, high-risk childbirth, and exposure to violence.
- **The psychological toll is severe.** Girls describe grief, anxiety, and loss of purpose long before any marriage takes place.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS

“Before the Taliban came, I had many goals. I wanted to take English courses and become a doctor... I reached grade 6 when the Taliban closed schools.”

Lima - married at 15

WHAT NEEDS TO HAPPEN

DONORS

Fund integrated education, protection, and psychosocial programs - not education projects alone.

UN AGENCIES

Treat girls' education as a child-protection priority and strengthen referral systems for girls at risk.

INTERNATIONAL COMMUNITY

Maintain diplomatic pressure on the Taliban and support Afghan women-led organizations.